

Identifying who's who

If there is more than one person or thing in a sentence, it must be clear which pronoun refers to which person or thing. If it is not clear, the sentence needs to be reworded. Alternatively, the name of the relevant person can be repeated to make it clear who is doing what.

In this case it was Anna's first climb, not Emily's, so the name *Anna* has been repeated to make this clear.

Emily wanted **Anna** to come, although it was **her** first climb. ❌

It is unclear whether it was Emily's first climb or Anna's.

Although it was **her** first climb, Emily wanted **Anna** to come. ✅

This sentence has been reordered so that the pronoun is next to the subject it relates to—it was Emily's first climb, not Anna's.

Emily wanted **Anna** to come, although it was **Anna's** first climb. ✅

Misusing *their*

The plural form *they* doesn't have a gender, and people often use this form when speaking or writing to avoid having to distinguish between males and females. In many cases, this results in a singular noun or pronoun being paired with a plural determiner. The only way to avoid this problem is to use *his* or *her* instead of *their* for the singular, or to make the noun plural and use *their*.

Everyone had to bring **his** or **her** own rope.

The indefinite pronoun *everyone* is singular, so the determiners *his* and *her* are used to refer to a group made up of males and females.

The students had to bring **their** own ropes.

The sentence has been reworded to include a plural subject (*students*), so the plural determiner *their* can be used. The object (*ropes*) has been made plural as well.

climbing expedition. The instructor had to bring **his** or **her** own rope.

Male or female?

Sometimes it's hard to know whether to use *he*, *she*, or *they* when referring to both men and women. Historically, writers used the masculine pronouns and determiners *he*, *his*, *him*, and *himself* to represent both sexes, but this approach is now considered outdated. Assumptions about male and female roles should also be avoided.

The instructor told **his** students to bring ropes.

This sentence refers to a specific instructor, who is known to be male, so the determiner *his* is correct.

An instructor must carry spare ropes for **his** or **her** students.

This sentence refers to an unknown instructor, who could be male or female, so the determiners *his* and *her* are required.

Instructors must carry spare ropes for **their** students.

Sometimes it's clearer to use both the noun and the determiner in the plural form.